

Digital lifelines: Virtual Spaces in Pandemic Latin America

The COVID-19 pandemic significantly reshaped social life across Latin America, acting as a form of what Rob Nixon terms “slow violence”—harm occurring gradually, often unnoticed, yet deeply impactful. Nixon describes slow violence as “violence that occurs gradually and out of sight, a violence of delayed destruction dispersed across time and space.” In the context of the pandemic, slow violence manifested not only through immediate health crises but also in prolonged psychological strain and socioeconomic hardships, particularly affecting vulnerable communities already challenged by poverty, inequality, and fragile healthcare systems.

Latin America’s rapid digital transition became a pivotal response to these conditions, profoundly altering social interactions, identity formation, and collective memory. As lockdown measures isolated populations, everyday life moved online and fundamentally shifted spatial dynamics. Henri Lefebvre’s concept of social space as a product of society—imbued with structures of control and power—offers a critical lens for understanding this transformation. Digital platforms became essential new social spaces, offering both connections across distances and imposing constraints through unequal access, surveillance, and algorithm-driven experiences. Thus, spatial justice emerged as a central concern, highlighting stark digital divides; nearly half of Latin Americans lacked reliable internet, disproportionately excluding poorer communities from virtual engagement.

This essay explores the multifaceted impacts of pandemic-induced digitalization, arguing that digital escapism—immersing oneself in virtual worlds, adopting online personas, and engaging in internet-mediated activism—provided crucial emotional coping mechanisms and opportunities for identity experimentation. However, it simultaneously introduced risks of deeper isolation, social fragmentation, and collective amnesia.

In this paper, I will first address isolation's mental health repercussions in Latin America, using psychological studies by Brooks et al. (2020) and Browning et al. (2021) and illustrating these impacts through Iuli Gerbase's film, *The Pink Cloud* (2021). Then, I will investigate digital escapism through gaming and avatar identities, focusing on how Latin American youth leveraged online games as social spaces for intimacy and self-exploration, drawing from Hugelmann's analysis (2023) and Michel Nieva's novel *Dengue Boy* (2025). In a third section, I will examine activism and collective memory, critically evaluating the effectiveness of "clicktivism" and its role in shaping societal responses to crises using insights from Puplampu (2023) and the Argentine film *Tóxico* (2020). Lastly, I explore the consequences of Latin America's digital shift during the pandemic as a double-edged sword demanding careful navigation.

Pandemic Isolation and Digital Space

The sudden isolation imposed by lockdowns had profound mental health consequences, which were widely documented in early 2020. A Lancet review by Brooks et al. (2020) warned that quarantine produces negative psychological effects including post-traumatic stress symptoms, confusion, and anger. Being cut off from normal life, many people experienced anxiety, depression, fear of infection, and even substance abuse. These effects often persisted long after the quarantine period. In Latin America, where lockdowns were among the strictest at times (cities like Buenos Aires, Lima, and others saw extended stay-at-home orders), such psychological strains were likely intense. Moreover, already-precarious conditions—crowded housing, economic insecurity—meant quarantine for the poor was both psychologically and materially harsh. Browning et al. (2021) identify college students as a particularly vulnerable population, noting higher levels of anxiety, depression, and loneliness among students when their education moved online. The abrupt shift to remote learning often meant young people were confined to their homes, separated from friends and campus life at a formative time. This psychological toll underscores why digital social spaces became so crucial as coping mechanisms.

Cut off from face-to-face interaction, people turned to technology to fill the void. Almost immediately, the internet became the new public square and living room. Families and friends connected via Zoom, WhatsApp, and social networks to reassure one another and maintain a semblance of normal social life. In Iuli Gerbase's Brazilian film *The Pink Cloud* (2021), which uncannily anticipated the pandemic, we see a vivid allegory of this dynamic. In the film, the characters Giovana and Yago rely on phone and video chat to reach their loved ones.. This mirrors the real-world behavior of millions under quarantine—Latin Americans included—who flocked to video calls and social media to stave off loneliness. Through screens, *The Pink Cloud's* characters celebrate birthdays, get news, and even receive medical consultations. The digital sphere becomes their lifeline to the outside world. This reflects Henri Lefebvre's idea that under changed conditions, society produces a new space to meet its needs. Here, digital space is produced as social space. The home, previously a private domestic space, is transformed into a multi-purpose zone of work, schooling, and socializing mediated by technology. The internet, once one domain of life, becomes the dominant space where daily rhythms unfold. Following Lefebvre, this virtual social space carries the values and power structures of society. On one hand, it is liberating—people can connect across distance. On the other, it is constrained by technology access and shaped by platform designs. Spatial practice takes on a new form: rather than meeting in a plaza or café, friends meet in a WhatsApp group; instead of classroom chatter, students chat in a Zoom window.

As isolation wears on, the psychological effects accumulate, even with digital connectivity. *The Pink Cloud* dramatizes the creeping mental strain. In one poignant subplot, Giovana's close friend is completely alone in her apartment for years. Deprived of human touch, she spirals into despair; her doctor prescribes antidepressants and she "buys a robot dog" for companionship (Gerbase 2021). This detail chillingly captures how technology was used to fill emotional voids in lockdown – a robot pet stands in for a real one, just as Zoom happy hours tried to mimic real social gatherings. We see here an element of estrangement: digital or artificial proxies offer some comfort but also underscore what is missing. The film's turning point comes when Giovana, in utter desperation, dons a virtual reality headset that her partner and son gift her. She escapes into an immersive simulation of a beach, sunning herself in VR while her physical body remains trapped at home. This scenario encapsulates digital escapism in its most literal form – the virtual world as an opiate for the pains of confinement. The VR beach provides a refuge from the stifling apartment and the existential dread of the pink cloud. Yet, it is a double-edged sword: Giovana's retreat into VR

becomes so consuming that she neglects her real child and health. When the headset is broken, she is forced to confront reality again. The audience is left to ponder whether such digital solace ultimately helps or harms.

Lefebvre's theory helps interpret this: the "lived space" (*espace vécu*) of these characters is fundamentally altered. Their subjective experience of space is now filtered through digital symbols (screens, VR images). Lefebvre would note that this lived space, though virtual, is real to them because it shapes their emotions and social relations. Meanwhile, power and control are evident: Giovana can only access the VR beach because a tech infrastructure allows it (and because she could afford it, thanks to the film establishing her as a web developer). Millions of Latin Americans, however, had no such luxury – many didn't even have reliable internet for basic Zoom calls. Thus, the pandemic digitalization was uneven, offering escape for some and frustration for others. The home as a space also changed its meaning. Latin American sociocultural norms, which highly value in-person conviviality (from communal dining to street festivals), were abruptly suspended. People had to re-imagine community. As one scholar observed early in the pandemic, social media became a "networked public" where quarantine stories, memes, and mutual support circulated to create a sense of togetherness despite physical separation (Santos 2024). This was a creative production of space: hashtags like #YoMeQuedoEnCasa ("I'm staying home") trended in Spanish, encouraging collective responsibility while also forging a digital community around the shared sacrifice of isolation.

However, digital togetherness had limits. The concept of slow violence is relevant: the harm of isolation (increased depression, developmental impacts on kids missing school, etc.) accrued slowly and was often hidden behind the façade of cheerful Instagram posts or Zoom backgrounds. Over time, the lack of physical co-presence may inflict a kind of quiet trauma – a generation less adept at face-to-face social skills or communities that have lost some communal bonds. The Latin American ethos of *abrazo* (hug) and street life could not be fully translated online. Furthermore, those endless video calls led to "Zoom fatigue," a new mental drain. Scholars like Lauricella and Small (2023) have critiqued how institutions addressed pandemic isolation. Universities and employers frequently sent messages of emotional support via email or social media – "We're here for you during this pandemic" – yet often did little to alleviate students' or workers' financial and emotional burdens. This performative corporate empathy highlights a dissonance in digital culture:

mediated communication can ring hollow when not backed by material action. The result for many Latin Americans was cynicism and erosion of trust in institutions, even as they remained glued to screens for guidance and news.

Gaming and Avatar Identities

Confined to their homes, many Latin Americans (especially youth) sought escape and social connection in digital games and virtual worlds. Video gaming, which was already popular in the region, surged during the pandemic as a form of entertainment and interaction that transcended physical distancing. In Brazil – Latin America’s largest gaming market – a 2021 survey found that 46% of responding gamers agreed they played more video games due to the pandemic (Statista 2021). Over 42% even reported spending more money on games during that period (Statista 2021). This uptick reflects a broader global trend: with traditional social outlets closed, multiplayer games became virtual hangouts. Whether it was teenagers gathering in Fortnite or university friends holding reunions in Animal Crossing, online games offered an imaginative space to be together. Crucially, they also allowed individuals to assume avatars – digital representations of the self that could be customized in appearance, abilities, even gender. Avatars and game personas gave people a chance to experiment with identity in ways that real life might not permit, a process particularly meaningful amid the identity crises and cabin fever brought on by lockdown.

Chris Hugelmann (2023) highlights the importance of these online game environments for identity formation and community building. His research on MMORPGs (Massively Multiplayer Online Role-Playing Games) shows how game interfaces and design affordances enable players to create identities and forge communities (Hugelmann 2023). The pandemic spurred many newcomers to join such virtual worlds or for lapsed gamers to return. For isolated individuals, the guilds, clans, and chat channels of a game could become a surrogate social circle. A college student stuck in a small apartment might log into World of Warcraft and suddenly be part of a team of 25 people cooperating to defeat a dragon, chatting in real time. The sense of shared purpose and achievement can be quite real. As Hugelmann notes, these games allow a “design of interfaces in MMORPGs for identity creation and community formation” (Hugelmann 2023). Players often report that their

avatars are extensions or aspects of themselves – sometimes idealized, sometimes exploring a different facet of their personality. During the pandemic, such identity play took on therapeutic dimensions.

Michel Nieva's novel *Dengue Boy* (2025) offers a literary exploration of identity fluidity and digital escapism taken to extremes. Although set in a post-apocalyptic future Argentina, the novel resonates with pandemic-era themes. From the start, Dengue Boy is an outsider – a literal insectoid body that defies human norms. This extreme sci-fi premise becomes a vehicle for examining how identity can be hybrid, multiple, and transgressive. This fantastical transformation can be read as a metaphor for the kind of identity experimentation that digital avatars allow. Just as Dengue Boy switches gender identification and embraces their Dengue-person latent power, in online spaces people often adopt cross-gender or non-human avatars to explore aspects of themselves. The pandemic's social disruption gave some people freedom to play with identity: freed from daily in-person scrutiny, individuals could present themselves online in chosen ways. Dengue Boy's wild narrative of a "giant, humanoid mosquito" navigating a dystopian world also satirizes the idea of digital embodiment. Nieva peppers the novel with references to virtual experiences – elite kids in the novel's future society "plug themselves into virtual headsets and immerse themselves in conquest fantasies like the game *Christians v Indians 2*" (Nieva 2025). This scenario echoes the pandemic reality where privileged youth, stuck at home, lost themselves in video games often with colonial or violent themes (a pointed critique by Nieva). The novel thus links virtual escapism with social critique: those wealthy enough to escape reality in VR do so by reenacting violent historical fantasies, while the protagonist (a marginalized being) insists on confronting and changing reality.

In Latin America's context, one might ask: did this turn to avatars and games have any lasting effect on identity and culture? Possibly yes. The pandemic cohort that spent formative years online may retain comfort with fluid identity and online self-expression. They might be more global in outlook, having befriended people across continents in games, and more adept at moving between different identity "modes" (one for physical life, one or more for online life). Scholars like Victoria Kannen (2023) have noted that we are at a "critical juncture" in understanding digital identities, as our online and offline selves merge in new ways (Kannen 2023). The Latin American experience, with its vibrant youth populations, creative arts scene, and sometimes volatile politics, adds a unique flavor to this phenomenon. For instance, we see emerging media where the boundaries

blur: virtual YouTubers (VTubers) with anime avatars gaining popularity in Spanish-speaking markets, or hybrid cultural productions (like a real-life reggaetón star giving a concert inside the game Fortnite, attended by thousands virtually from Latin America). Such developments suggest that avatar-mediated identity has become mainstreamed out of what was, during the pandemic, a subcultural refuge.

Yet, there is a flip side. Psychologists caution that excessive gaming can become problematic or addictive, leading to neglect of real-life duties and health. During COVID-19, there were reports of young people flipping their sleep schedules to play games all night, or family conflicts over screen time. The boundary between healthy escapism and harmful withdrawal is thin. Moreover, not everyone found acceptance online; toxic behavior and harassment in gaming communities can just as easily compound someone's stress. Women and LGBTQ players often face discrimination in voice chats, which could worsen the isolation they sought to remedy. These nuances are a reminder that virtual identity experimentation, while liberating, is not utopian – digital culture carries the same prejudices and power imbalances as society at large, sometimes amplified by anonymity.

Activism, “Slacktivism,” and Collective Memory

Even as people retreated into private spheres during lockdown, the world's social and political issues did not pause – if anything, they grew more urgent. Latin America in 2020–2021 saw numerous crises: economic downturns, protests against inequality, and global movements like Black Lives Matter (BLM) resonating locally. With streets off-limits due to virus fears or restrictions, activism largely moved online. This provoked debates about the effectiveness of digital activism, often derided as “slacktivism” or “clicktivism” – pejorative terms suggesting that clicking “Like” on a cause or posting a hashtag is a lazy substitute for real action. Adiki Puplampu (2023) argues that this view is oversimplified and that pandemic-era online activism demonstrated both the power and pitfalls of digital engagement. In their chapter “Reassessing Clicktivism: A Tool of the (Pandemic) Times,” Puplampu and Macpherson note that “lockdowns forced people around the globe to stay home..., resulting in increased exposure, via various media, to local and global social issues. This intensified social consciousness... fostered clicktivism as a primary

method of social activism, shedding new light on its qualities, both positive and negative” (Puplampu and Macpherson 2023). In other words, far from being purely apathetic, millions of people were deeply engaged with issues online – precisely because they had little else to do and were glued to news on their devices.

Critics of online activism worry that it is performative – more about expressing oneself than achieving change. The psychological gratification of online activism (the dopamine of likes and shares) might convince some they’ve “done enough,” a phenomenon known as moral self-licensing or moral balancing – doing a small good deed and then excusing oneself from further action. However, Puplampu and Macpherson contend that this cynicism is not entirely fair. During 2020, many Latin American activists who began by sharing posts ended up attending Zoom teach-ins, donating to bail funds abroad or mutual aid at home, and later, when it was safer, joining physical protests (in Brazil, protests against racism and President Bolsonaro drew on momentum built online). Clicktivism, in this view, was a gateway to civic engagement rather than a dead end. Moreover, in a time when “public health orders [were] prohibiting large gatherings,” online activism was often the only viable form of protest (Puplampu and Macpherson 2023). One could argue that under these constraints, digital activism became “real activism,” achieving awareness-raising at an unprecedented scale. The sheer virality of information on social media meant that ideas spread faster in 2020 than they could have through on-the-ground organizing alone.

The breakdown of a shared reality undermines the possibility of collective action. If citizens cannot even agree on basic facts (e.g., “the virus is real” or “masks help”), forming a united front to demand better health measures or economic support becomes difficult. *Tóxico* dramatizes distrust at the interpersonal level: Laura and Augusto decide to trust no one but each other, essentially giving up on society. Likewise, during COVID-19 some communities in Latin America turned inward – neighborhoods barricaded themselves to outsiders, or middle-class families withdrew behind gates, fearing the other as a vector of disease. This social fragmentation is the opposite of solidarity. It is notable that Latin America saw both extremes: tremendous solidarity (neighborhood soup kitchens, volunteer groups delivering food to the vulnerable) and tremendous fragmentation (wealthy areas getting privileged access to medical care, marginalized groups being scapegoated for spreading illness). Digital media could serve both: enabling solidarity (through

mutual aid coordination on WhatsApp) or amplifying fragmentation (through WhatsApp rumors demonizing certain groups).

Digital Worlds as Double-Edged Swords

Throughout this analysis, a recurring theme has been ambivalence: the very technologies and virtual spaces that helped Latin Americans endure the pandemic also carried inherent contradictions. These digital worlds were refuges that enabled continuity of life – and at times, sources of entrapment that threatened to supplant reality or exacerbate divides. They allowed identities to become fluid and communities to form in new ways – and yet they sometimes fragmented the collective into isolated bubbles. In short, the impact of pandemic digitalization on identity and society was double-edged.

Return to *The Pink Cloud*: the film’s ending is profoundly ambivalent. After years inside, when a false alarm suggests the toxic cloud might be gone, Giovana becomes elated at the prospect of freedom – only for hope to be snatched away as the pink cloud reasserts itself (Gerbase 2021). In the final scene, Giovana steps onto the balcony, counting to ten, seemingly ready to risk death rather than continue her suffocating existence (Gerbase 2021). It’s left ambiguous whether she survives or not. This speaks to the ultimate inadequacy of the digital cocoon she’s lived in. Yes, the internet, VR, and screens kept her alive and sane for a long time, but in the end her human need for real freedom – to occupy real space – overpowers the virtual comforts.

Likewise, Nieva’s *Dengue Boy* illustrates the double edge of digital escapism by contrasting the fates of its characters. The privileged “viroeconomy” kids who escape into VR games and grotesque virtual pleasures (like the “sheepies” sex devices) live in a state of numbed disconnect (Nieva 2025). They are practically co-conspirators in the dystopia, as their immersion in fantasy lets the real world’s injustices continue unchecked. On the other hand, Dengue Person – who cannot partake in these elite virtual escapes – is the one to exact justice (albeit violently) by literally hunting down those responsible for societal suffering (Nieva 2025). Nieva seems to suggest that escapism can be a form of complacency. Those plugged into comforting virtual realities might be

blinded to slow violence happening around them, whereas those who are forced to confront reality (no matter how horrific) might catalyze change.

Digital spaces have also proven to be exclusionary in new ways. In terms of inclusion, the pandemic showed both gains and losses. On one side, remote connectivity allowed inclusion of people who historically were left out: individuals with disabilities could attend events and classes without the barrier of transportation; people from rural areas could dial into urban-centric cultural activities; even shyer personalities could “find their voice” in chat-based communications.. There was a sense that the playing field leveled in some respects – everyone was communicating through the same digital medium, so accommodations became more standard. This hints at a potential democratizing effect of digital spaces. Additionally, the norm of working from home opened job opportunities for some who couldn’t relocate or travel. These are positives that many are reluctant to lose. However, on the other side, the digital divide we discussed meant many were outright excluded. Those without broadband or devices were effectively silenced in the new public sphere. Even among the connected, not all digital spaces are welcoming. Social media algorithms can create echo chambers that exclude opposing views, leading to further polarization. And marginalized groups often face harassment online that mirrors or exceeds offline prejudice. The term “digital inclusion” involves not just access, but also the ability to participate safely and meaningfully.

Spatial justice is another facet of the double-edged nature of digital space. Lefebvre argued that space (including virtual space) can be a means of domination (Lefebvre 1991). We saw that with how Big Tech companies reaped enormous profits as everyone depended on their platforms. Control over digital infrastructure became a power lever. Governments too leveraged digital space for control: some implemented surveillance apps for quarantine tracking, raising privacy fears. In some cases, the pandemic response served as a pretext for expanding state surveillance via digital means. This is slow violence in a sense – citizens may not immediately feel the impact, but gradually such measures can erode civil liberties. Yet, digital space also empowered activists to watchdog abuses and organize (as discussed). Thus, the political dimension of digital escapism is paradoxical: it can anesthetize or mobilize, liberate or monitor.

To conclude, the COVID-19 pandemic acted as a catalyst for digital transformation across Latin America, compelling societies to adapt rapidly to virtual environments for work, education, and social interaction. This shift unveiled both the potential and the pitfalls of digital escapism. On one hand, digital platforms provided essential lifelines, enabling continuity in various aspects of daily life and offering avenues for emotional coping and identity exploration. On the other hand, they exposed and, in some cases, exacerbated existing social inequalities, particularly for those lacking reliable internet access or digital literacy.

The reliance on digital spaces highlighted issues of spatial justice, as access to virtual environments became a new determinant of inclusion or exclusion. While some individuals found empowerment and community online, others faced heightened isolation and marginalization. The digital divide underscored the necessity for equitable infrastructure and inclusive policies to ensure that technological advancements benefit all segments of society.

Moreover, the phenomenon of digital escapism raised concerns about the long-term implications for mental health and societal cohesion. While virtual realities offered temporary solace, they also risked detachment from the physical world and the erosion of shared experiences and collective memory. The challenge lies in balancing the benefits of digital engagement with the need for authentic human connection and community resilience.

Lastly, the pandemic-induced digital shift in Latin America serves as a double-edged sword, offering both opportunities for innovation and risks of deepening societal divides. Moving forward, it is imperative to harness the positive aspects of digitalization while addressing its challenges through inclusive policies, equitable access, and a commitment to preserving the human elements of society.

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